



CJ 540

Qualitative Field Research

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What is qualitative field research?



EXPLANATORY RESEARCH AIMED AT EXPLAINING
SOCIAL LIFE IN NON-NUMERIC WAYS

INVESTIGATION OF SOCIAL WORLD IN NATURAL
SETTINGS

DATA-CENTRIC, INDUCTIVE METHOD OF
INVESTIGATION

What is qualitative field research suited for?

- PRACTICES
- ATTITUDES
- BEHAVIORS
- EPISODES
- ENCOUNTERS
- ROLES
- SOCIAL RELATIONSHIPS
- GROUPS AND CLIQUES
- ORGANIZATIONS
- SETTLEMENTS AND HABITATS
- SOCIAL WORLDS
- SUBCULTURES AND LIFESTYLES



The Role of Grounded Theory

- Understandings of the social world and relationships between variables drawn from data
 - Inductive approach to generate theory from the constant comparing of observations.
 - Analysis of common patterns, themes, categories from observations.
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Stages

DESIGNING:

procedure & materials (deciding on themes to cover), IRB approval

DATA COLLECTION:

talking with participants

TRANSCRIBING:

translating recorded interview to text

ANALYZING:

identifying patterns in text, aligned themes

REPORTING:

writing up results

QUALITATIVE APPROACHES TO RESEARCH

INTERVIEW

ETHNOGRAPHY

PARTICIPANT-
OBSERVATION

CASE STUDY

FOCUS GROUP

CONTENT
ANALYSIS

Obtrusive

DIRECT OBSERVATIONS THAT
CAN AFFECT SOCIAL LIFE

- INTERVIEW
- ETHNOGRAPHY
- PARTICIPANT-OBSERVATION
- CASE STUDY
- FOCUS GROUP

Unobtrusive

INDIRECT OBSERVATIONS
THAT DON'T AFFECT
SOCIAL LIFE

- CONTENT ANALYSIS
- CASE STUDY (HISTORICAL)

Obtrusive Qualitative Methods

Interview



ONE-ON-ONE INTERVIEW WITH PARTICIPANT

QUESTIONS (INTERVIEW GUIDE)

- designed to uncover experiences/perceptions
- based on set of predetermined themes yet not wed to questions (loosely-followed guide)
- topics to be discussed in depth rather than using standardized questions

Ethnography

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF SOCIAL LIFE IN A SETTING.
RESEARCHER SPENDS EXTENSIVE TIME IN SETTING,
RECORDING

- sights
 - sounds
 - smells
 - tastes
 - sensations
 - feelings
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Participant- Observation



LIVING IN OR MAKING FREQUENT VISITS TO THE SETTING STUDIED
OBSERVING AND/OR PARTICIPATING IN THE ACTIVITIES OF THE
SETTING

DECIDE ON SPECTRUM OF PARTICIPATION, FROM FULL
PARTICIPANT TO FULL OBSERVER.

Focus Group



MULTIPLE PARTICIPANTS INTERVIEWED TOGETHER,
PROMPTING FURTHER DISCUSSION.

DESIGN



Case Study



IN-DEPTH EXAMINATION OF A SINGLE INSTANCE OF SOME SOCIAL PHENOMENON

- Develops an idiographic understanding of a particular case which could be used as the basis for looking at other cases and developing nomothetic models
 - Studying one person's experience with the legal system, used as the basis for studying others

Unobtrusive Qualitative Methods

Historical Case Study



IN-DEPTH EXAMINATION OF A SINGLE INSTANCE OF SOME SOCIAL PHENOMENON, USING PRIOR HUMAN RECORDED COMMUNICATIONS

COMPARES ONE CASE WITH OTHER *MOST SIMILAR* OR *MOST DISTINCT* CASES

Content Analysis



THE STUDY OF RECORDED HUMAN COMMUNICATIONS (TEXT).

“WHO SAYS WHAT, TO WHOM, WHY, HOW, AND WITH WHAT EFFECT?”

DESIGN



Best Practices

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GAINING ENTRÉE (ENTRY/ACCESS)

INFORMANTS OR GATEKEEPERS

Best Practices



PARTICIPANT, RESEARCHER, OBSERVER

- Reactivity – The problem when participants under study know they're being studied and react by altering their behavior from what it would have been normally.
- Relations to Subjects
 - Objectivity
 - Reflexivity



Best Practices



BEGIN WITH A GENERAL QUESTION:

- Does X lead to Y?

BUT DON'T LET QUESTION GUIDE THE RESEARCH

- Ask about Y, but also about their perceptions about how X influenced Y, and about Z



Best Practices



RELY ON OPEN-ENDED QUESTIONS

- Do not use questions that can be answered with “one word” (e.g. yes, no, idk, etc).
- “Have you..”
- “Do you...”
- “did you...”
- “why did you”
- “are you”



Best Practices

SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEW

- RELIES ON INTERVIEW GUIDE
 - A LOOSE SET OF QUESTIONS THAT GUIDE YOUR LINE OF THINKING
 - CAN DEFINITELY DEVIATE FROM THOSE QUESTIONS
 - LET THE PARTICIPANT GUIDE THE INTERVIEW, BUT DON'T BE AFRAID TO COME BACK TO IT
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Best Practices

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MINER VS. TRAVELER

Best Practices



RECORDING OBSERVATIONS

- Ask participants for permission to digitally record
- Take detailed notes, but balance with observations
- Rewrite notes with observations (soon after observed) with filled in details
- Record empirical observations and interpretations of them (what you “know” and “think” happened)



Best Practices



MEMOS & NOTES

- When doing field research, important to take notes/memos while in field & record conversations/interactions
- Notes converted to text
- Text is analyzed



Best Practices



MEMOS & NOTES

- describe and define concepts (Code)
- deal with methodological issues (Operational)
- offer initial theoretical ideas (Theoretical)

